Cabinet briefing · March 2027

Defensible-Space Standard

Whether to mandate 30-meter vegetation clearance for the 41,000 homes in the wildland-urban interface.

The bottom line: mandate the clearance standard, phased over three fire seasons.

A statewide 30-meter defensible-space requirement is the single intervention that most reduces structure loss per dollar. We recommend adopting it now, with a graduated enforcement schedule and a hardship grant for low-income owners.

Last season's losses concentrated where vegetation met structures.

The 2026 Coyote Ridge fire destroyed 612 homes. Post-incident survey found 83% of lost structures had less than 10 meters of cleared vegetation; 91% of surviving structures within the same burn perimeter exceeded 20 meters.

- Clearance, not construction year, was the strongest predictor of survival.
- The pattern repeats across four of the last five major incidents.

Voluntary guidance has not moved compliance in eight years.

The interface has carried a *recommended* 30-meter guideline since 2019. Self-reported audits put voluntary compliance at 34% — flat since the guideline was issued, and concentrated in higher-income parcels with the means to clear.

Three policy paths, scored against what the standard must achieve.

Keep voluntary guidance.

✓ Low cost ✗ Compliance gain ✗ Equity reach

Cheapest to administer, but eight years of flat compliance show it does not change behavior at scale.

Mandate with no support.

✗ Low cost ✓ Compliance gain ✗ Equity reach

Drives compliance but lands hardest on owners who cannot afford clearance, inviting non-compliance and appeals.

Mandate with hardship grants.

⊖ Low cost ✓ Compliance gain ✓ Equity reach

Achieves the compliance gain while funding the owners least able to clear. Recommended.

Evidence · Modeled outcomes

What the mandated standard buys over a five-year horizon.

Modeled against the 2019–2026 incident record, applied to the current interface parcel set.

−58%
PROJECTED STRUCTURE LOSS

41,000
PARCELS BROUGHT TO STANDARD

$312M
AVOIDED REBUILD COST

6,400
HARDSHIP GRANTS FUNDED

What any acceptable standard had to satisfy.

01

Measurable loss reduction

Must show a defensible link to reduced structure loss, not just activity.

02

Enforceable at scale

Compliance must be verifiable across 41,000 parcels without doubling inspection staff.

03

Equitable burden

Cost must not fall hardest on the owners least able to bear it.

04

Fundable within the envelope

Total cost must fit the $340M resilience appropriation already authorised.

Where each path sits on enforceability against equity.

Hard to enforce · Inequitable.

Status quo voluntary guidance

Hard to enforce · Equitable.

Incentive-only tax rebates

Enforceable · Inequitable.

Flat mandate, no support

Enforceable · Equitable.

Mandate with hardship grants

What the standard costs across the three-season phase-in.

01	Year 1 — high-risk zones	9,200 parcels, including 1,800 hardship grants.	$74M
02	Year 2 — moderate-risk zones	18,600 parcels, including 3,100 grants.	$121M
03	Year 3 — remaining interface	13,200 parcels, including 1,500 grants.	$98M
04	Recurring — inspection & renewal	Annually from Year 4, absorbed by the resilience fund.	$14M

The chief risk is enforcement capacity, and it is addressable.

Inspecting 41,000 parcels needs roughly 40 additional seasonal inspectors. We propose remote-sensing pre-screening to triage parcels, reserving field visits for likely non-compliance — cutting required headcount by an estimated 60%.

Adopt the mandated 30-meter standard with hardship grants, phased over three seasons.

ADOPT MANDATE WITH GRANTS

Delivers the loss reduction while funding the owners least able to clear.

WHY NOT STAY VOLUNTARY

Eight years of flat compliance show guidance alone does not change behavior.

WHY NOT MANDATE WITHOUT SUPPORT

Equitable burden was a hard requirement; an unfunded mandate fails it.

Office of Wildfire Resilience · resilience.gov.example

A standard that survives the next fire season, not just this briefing.